

**An Inclusive Toolkit for Supporting Adolescent Learners with Special Education Needs in
Mainstream Schools**

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“When a flower doesn’t bloom, you fix the environment in which it grows, not the flower.”

Alexander den Heijer



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This experience has been one of growth, reflection, and gratitude — a powerful reminder that education, at its core, is an act of shared purpose, compassion, and hope.

Biography

Shirley Charles is an educator from Singapore with nearly 20 years of experience in pre-university teaching. She currently serves as Head of Department at Yishun Innova Junior College, which primarily serves students aged 17-18. In her role, she oversees both the General Paper and English Literature units and supports teachers in delivering rigorous, developmentally appropriate learning experiences for late adolescents. As the college's Academic Strategic Thrust Owner, she also guides academic planning and programme review through the Academic Steering Committee.

Beyond curriculum leadership, Shirley is committed to student well-being, particularly in supporting those with social-emotional and special educational needs. Her team was recently recognised with Outstanding Contribution Awards for their work in the Case Management Team, and for the development of a two-year Parent Education Curriculum which she spearheaded to strengthen home – school partnerships. A mother of three, she credits raising children with diverse personalities and interests for shaping her empathy and adaptability as an educator. Shirley graduated with Second Upper Honours from the Wee Kim Wee School of Communication and Information at Nanyang Technological University, and later obtained an Postgraduate Diploma in Education from the National Institute of Education.

Executive Summary

Despite three decades of global advocacy since the Salamanca Statement (UNESCO, 1994), many teachers still feel ill-equipped to translate the ideals of inclusive education into everyday classroom practice. In Singapore, sustained policy attention and resource development have advanced inclusion for students with special educational needs (SEN), yet

classroom implementation remains uneven – particularly at the secondary and post-secondary levels, where support structures taper off and expectations for conformity increase.

Effective inclusion begins not with strategies alone, but with teacher mindset and understanding. When teachers appreciate the diverse challenges that SEN students face – such as difficulties with social communication, executive functioning, or sensory processing – they are better equipped to provide meaningful accommodations and create learning environments where all students can participate fully. Building this professional understanding is therefore central to ensuring that inclusion is not viewed as an additional task, but as a natural extension of good teaching.

Adolescence, in particular, is a critical yet often overlooked stage in the inclusion journey. As students move toward adulthood, they encounter increasingly complex academic, social, and emotional demands. For those with SEN, this period magnifies gaps in existing systems. Inclusive practice at this stage requires teachers who not only provide supports but who can also cultivate confidence, independence, and social connectedness – preparing learners to thrive beyond the protective structures of school.

This project, *An Inclusive Toolkit for Supporting Adolescent Learners in Mainstream Schools*, responds directly to the need for better support structures and pedagogical approaches tailored to adolescents with SEN. The toolkit focuses on strengthening teachers' understanding of learner variability and building inclusive mindsets that inform classroom practice. The Inclusive Teacher Toolkit distils research-based frameworks – such as the Individual Education Plan (IEP), and Universal Design for Learning (UDL) CAST (2024) – into

practical, accessible resources that guide teachers in designing for diversity rather than accommodating reactively.

Ultimately, the Inclusive Teacher Toolkit promotes a vision of inclusion rooted in empathy, understanding, and intentional design. By equipping teachers to support adolescent learners with greater awareness and confidence, it reinforces that inclusive education begins with teacher mindset – the belief that every learner, regardless of ability, deserves the opportunity to participate meaningfully and to flourish as they prepare for adulthood and life beyond school.

Overview of the Topic Area

In recent decades, the global movement toward inclusive education has gained momentum, recognising that schools should be places where all learners are valued and able to participate fully. The Salamanca Statement (UNESCO, 1994) was pivotal in shaping this agenda, positioning inclusion as both a human right and an educational priority. It emphasised that mainstream schools with “an inclusive culture and inclusive policies are the most effective forms of education to combat discriminatory attitudes, and to sensitise young people to diversity and difference from an early age” (UNESCO, 2024, p.6). Thirty years after the Salamanca Statement, UNESCO (2024) reported that despite widespread commitments by many countries to inclusive education, significant challenges persist in translating these commitments into effective practice.

Building on the global inclusivity agenda, schools worldwide have made notable progress in welcoming students with special educational needs (SEN) into mainstream classrooms. Yet, students with SEN remain a diverse group, with needs ranging from academic

support to assistance with social-emotional adaptation and executive functioning. Because these learners often face disproportionate challenges due to their circumstances, it is essential to create supportive classroom cultures and instructional practices that enable students with SEN and their peers to thrive together. As Charamba and Ndhlovana (2025) note, the pursuit of inclusivity remains both a pressing necessity and a complex challenge, with schools standing at a critical juncture – either amplifying inequities or acting as agents of transformation. For students with SEN, their academic growth, social adaptation, and overall well-being depend on systems of support that are not only present but also meaningfully responsive to their diverse developmental and social needs.

Within the broader landscape of global inclusion efforts, more attention should be paid to adolescents with SEN. This developmental stage warrants particular focus for two key reasons. First, adolescents tend to receive less targeted support compared to younger children, as they are often expected to conform to mainstream expectations within more academically demanding and socially complex environments. Second, adolescents require purposeful transition support that extends beyond classroom accommodations. Such support involves building behavioural, social, and adaptive competencies that prepare them to navigate less structured post-school settings and to transition successfully into adulthood and the world of work. These competencies are essential for fostering independence, resilience, and positive interpersonal relationships—capabilities that determine whether inclusion extends meaningfully beyond the school environment.

Recognising these adolescent-specific challenges highlights the need for practical, evidence-based approaches that address overlapping needs across diverse learners. In

response, the Inclusive Teacher Toolkit adopts a broader, needs-based framing rather than focusing on a single diagnostic category. Many challenges commonly associated with specific SEN profiles—such as social communication difficulties, variability in classroom participation, or executive functioning demands—are shared across a wide range of learners. By concentrating on these cross-cutting needs, teachers can implement strategies that are concrete, adaptable, and relevant to multiple learner profiles. Framing inclusion in this way emphasises the shift from providing access alone to cultivating equity and a genuine sense of belonging for all students in mainstream school.

The Singapore Context

Singapore is an island city-state, that has marked 60 years of independence since 1965. It consistently ranks among the top performers in international assessments of educational attainment, such as the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development's Programme for International Student Assessment. This success is often attributed to the sustained investments in education initiated by its founding Prime Minister, the late Lee Kuan Yew, and carried forward by subsequent successors. Lee viewed the development of human capital as Singapore's most important natural resource—an outlook that has profoundly shaped national policies and established education as a central pillar of the country's social and economic progress (Yiannouka, 2015).

The present landscape of special education in Singapore reflects a gradual process of system-wide development. From its origins in charity-based provision before independence, it transitioned to government-led services in the 1970s and later to specialised schools for students with diverse disabilities in the 1980s and 1990s (Lim & Sang, 2000). While these

expansions broadened access, they also gave rise to a dual system of education: mainstream and special schools (Poon et al., 2013). While Singapore was not a signatory to the Salamanca Statement and Framework for Action on Special Needs Education, Singapore signed the United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD) in 2012 and ratified the convention on 18 July 2013 (Ministry of Social & Family Development, 2022).

Significant reforms in the decades since have strengthened the national commitment to inclusion. From 2004 onward, when then Prime Minister Lee Hsien Loong highlighted the integration of students with SEN into mainstream schools (Lee, 2004) the government has progressively expanded systemic support through initiatives such as the introduction of Allied Educators (Learning and Behavioural Support), enhanced teacher training at the National Institute of Education, early intervention programmes, and barrier-free facilities (Lim & Thaver, 2018).

These SEN developments have markedly increased the number of students with SEN enrolled in mainstream education (Lim & Meng, 2021). Of the approximately 35,500 students with reported SEN, about 80 percent are in mainstream schools, with the remainder in specialised schools for those with more severe needs (Ministry of Education, 2023). While this reflects strong national efforts toward inclusion, current resources have not fully kept pace with growing demand. The deployment of over 700 SEN Officers – typically two in each primary school and one in each secondary school – provides important support (Elangovan, 2023), yet remains limited as increasing numbers of students with SEN transition into secondary and post-secondary settings. Teachers and educational experts have noted that these students often face

difficulties with organisation, time management, and adapting to new academic structures in junior colleges and universities (Ang, 2022).

These SEN resource and transition challenges highlight the need to strengthen teacher capacity across all levels so that evidence-based, inclusive strategies are embedded across all levels of the education system rather than concentrated only in specialised support roles. In line with this, the Ministry of Education (2025) has committed to upskilling teachers to enact evidence-based instructional practices, which are essential for students with and beneficial for all learners and to strengthen the alignment between teachers' classroom instruction and SEN officer's support to achieve stronger student outcomes.

Literature Review

Shifts in Thinking around Special Education

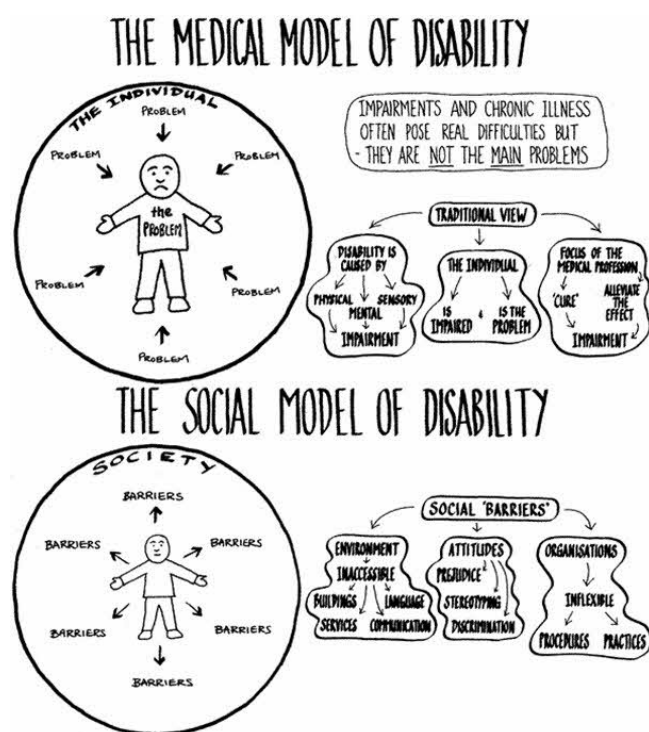
Earlier approaches to disability were dominated by the medical model, which framed disability as an individual impairment requiring treatment or remediation. Within education, this often meant focusing on fixing the learner so they could fit into existing structures, typically resulting in segregated provision or specialised interventions (Donaldson et al., 2017). While this model addressed certain needs, it reinforced deficit perspectives and limited opportunities for authentic inclusion.

In contrast, more recent thinking is shaped by the social model, which arose in the late twentieth century as part of the disability rights movement (Oliver, 1996). The social model shifts the focus away from the individual and onto the systemic, recognising disability as the result of physical, institutional, and attitudinal barriers in society (Donaldson et al., 2017). This perspective laid the groundwork for inclusive education by emphasising the responsibility of

schools and communities to transform structures and practices so that all learners can participate equitably. As illustrated in Figure 1, the medical model locates disability within the individual, whereas the social model situates it in environmental and societal barriers.

Figure 1

Medial and Social Models of Disability



(Neurodiverse Inclusive Central E-network, 2017)

Contemporary special education has also been influenced by historical and political forces, including parent advocacy, civil rights movements, and legislation affecting both general and special education (Bursuck & Friend, 2019). As a result, twenty-first-century schools face both the privilege and the challenge of fostering inclusive environments where all learners are valued and supported (Sabando et al., 2019).

Inclusive Education

Inclusive education is understood as expanding the capacity of schools to meet the needs of all learners through adaptations in content, pedagogy, environment, and systems (UNESCO, 2009), while also ensuring that students with special needs are educated, as far as possible, in general classrooms within their community schools, supported by trained professionals (Council for Exceptional Children, 2009). Grounded in human rights principles, inclusive education is both a political and ethical imperative (Hedegaard, 2012). Politically, it has become a policy priority across many nations following the 1994 World Conference on Special Needs Education, where the Salamanca Statement called for the development of inclusive schools as the most effective means of combating discrimination and promoting equal participation (UNESCO, 1994). Ethically, inclusion is affirmed as a fundamental human right, emphasising that every learner should have access to education that meets their needs within regular school settings (Mentz & Barrett, 2011).

Inclusive education offers multiple benefits across academic, social, and economic dimensions. From an educational standpoint, it enhances learning opportunities for both students with and without disabilities, as all learners can access the strategies, resources, and specialised support designed to meet diverse needs (UNESCO, 2009). Socially, shared classrooms foster greater tolerance, empathy, and understanding of individual differences, helping to shift broader societal attitudes toward persons with disabilities (Carter & Abawi, 2018). Economically, inclusion is also more efficient, as educating students together in mainstream schools is less costly than establishing separate institutions with specialised facilities (UNESCO, 2009).

Adolescents with SEN: Developmental Challenges and Support Needs

Adolescence represents the transitional bridge between childhood and adulthood and is marked by developmental milestones unique to this stage. Healthy cognitive, physical, and psychosocial development is both a right and a necessity for enabling adolescents to successfully enter adulthood (American Academy of Pediatrics, 2019). For many young people, particularly those with SEN, this period is especially challenging. Greater independence is expected and necessary for future success (Bursuck & Friend, 2019), yet many students—including those with SEN—lack fundamental independent skills. The transition years provide an ideal opportunity to explicitly teach these skills. Research highlights five key areas in which students need to develop independence: gaining information, storing and retrieving information, expressing information, self-advocacy, and time management (Deshler et al., 2001). In addition, they must be supported in acquiring other essential life skills that will maximise their independence in adulthood.

Evidence-based approaches for inclusive education

Individualised Education Programme

The Individualised Education Programme (IEP) is a cornerstone of special education, designed to tailor instruction and support to the unique needs of students with SEN. Originating from the United States' Individuals with Disabilities Education Act, the IEP serves as a collaborative framework that brings together teachers, parents, school administrators, related service personnel, and, where appropriate, the student (U.S. Department of Education, 2000). An IEP guides decisions about placement, annual goals and short-term objectives, accommodations, and service provision, while also offering a structured method for monitoring

progress (Wright et al., 2014; Yell et al., 2016) and is accessible to all teachers who have SEN students in their classroom. (Meyer et al., 2014). While states in the U.S. have flexibility about the additional information they require in an IEP, the minimum required include current grade level performance, annual goals, services offered, and other requirements. Table 1 lists IEP requirements and describes their content.

Table 1

Contents of an IEP

Current Performance	States how the child is doing in school (tests, assignments, evaluations, and observations). Explains how the disability affects progress in the general curriculum.
Annual Goals	Measurable goals for one year, with short-term objectives. May be academic, social, behavioral, physical, or other needs.
Special Education and Related Services	Lists services, aids, modifications, and supports (including staff training) provided to the child.
Participation with Nondisabled Children	Explains the extent the child will (or will not) join regular classes and activities.
Participation in Tests	Lists testing modifications or alternatives if standard tests aren't appropriate.
Dates and Places	States when services begin, how often, where, and for how long.
Transition Services Needs	From age 14, lists courses and planning needed for post-school goals.
Needed Transition Services	From age 16, specifies services to prepare for leaving school.
Age of Majority	At least one year before majority, informs student of rights that will transfer (if applicable).
Measuring Progress	Explains how progress will be measured and how parents will be informed of progress.

(U.S. Government of State, 2000)

For students who present with significant behavioural challenges, the IEP must also incorporate an intervention plan informed by a functional assessment of the behaviour, ensuring that support strategies are targeted and evidence-based (Oram et al., 2016). Such approaches align closely with the principles of Positive Behaviour Support (PBS), which emphasises proactive, functional, and individualised interventions to improve students' behaviour and learning outcomes.

Universal Design for Learning

Universal Design of Learning (UDL) CAST (2024) offers a framework that challenges the traditional approach of planning instruction for the “mythical middle,” (Stein, 2016, p.19) where teachers assume that exposure to content alone is sufficient for learning. UDL emphasises the proactive design of curricula so that all students can access and meaningfully engage with content, shifting the focus from fixing the learner to fixing the curriculum (Meyer et al., 2014). Central to UDL is the recognition of learner variability – grounded in neuroscience, which shows that each brain is unique and that emotions, motivation, and cognitive diversity significantly shape learning experiences. Stein (2016) argues that variability is inherent in every classroom and that SEN represent only one dimension of this diversity. This variability underscores the importance of designing flexible environments that value learners' diverse strengths rather than viewing differences through a deficit lens (Meyer et al., 2014).

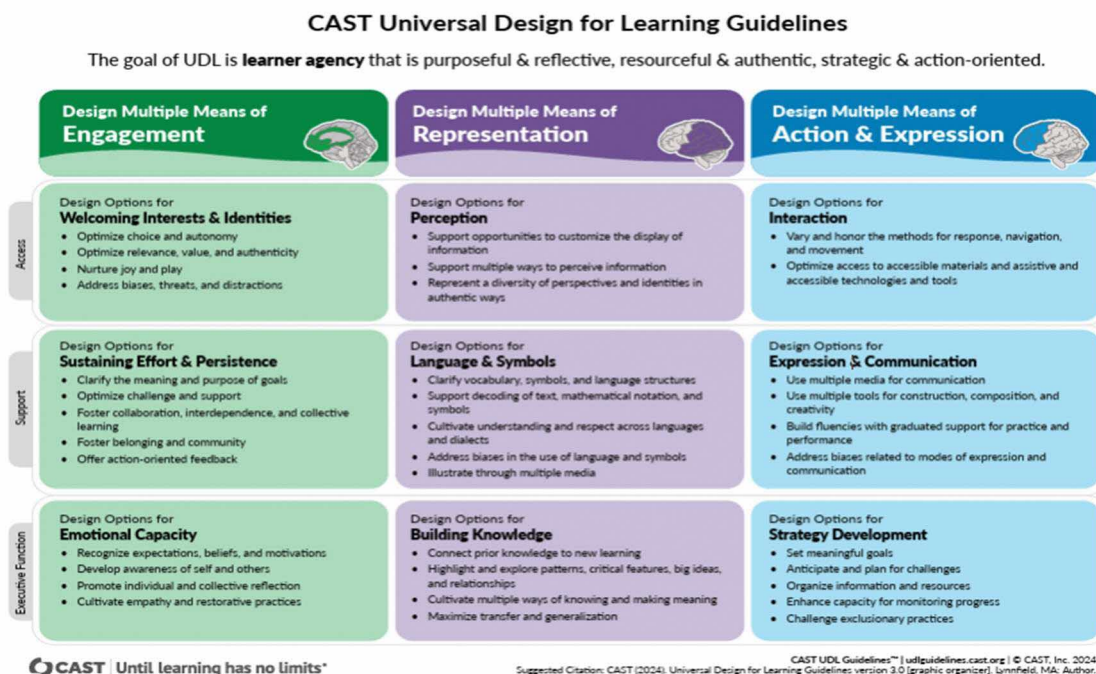
The UDL framework is organised around three guiding principles:

- **Multiple Means of Representation** (The "*What*" of Learning): Present information in various formats to address different learning styles and cognitive abilities.
- **Multiple Means of Action and Expression** (The "*How*" of Learning): Give students a range of options for demonstrating what they know and can do.
- **Multiple Means of Engagement** (The "*Why*" of Learning): Offer multiple ways to motivate and sustain learners' interest in learning.

These principles, summarised in the CAST (2024) UDL Guidelines and presented in Figure 2, provide practical strategies for educators to plan lessons that embrace learner variability from the outset. Importantly, while UDL is particularly beneficial for students with special educational needs, its design benefits all learners by fostering equity, participation, and authentic engagement in diverse classrooms. Beyond K–12 settings, studies show that UDL also enhances the experiences of students with disabilities during their transition to postsecondary education and careers, improving both access and use of available services (Beck et al., 2014; Scott et al., 2022). The UDL Guidelines (Cast, 2024) thus serve as a practical tool to anticipate barriers and design flexible pathways for diverse learners across educational contexts.

Figure 2

Guidelines for Universal Design for Learning



(CAST, 2024)

Primary Observations

Through my observations in U.S. classrooms and discussions with teachers, I gained valuable insights into how students are supported within an inclusive education system.

A key takeaway was the central role of the IEP in supporting students with SEN. The IEP functions not only as a planning tool for setting clear, measurable goals but also as a communication bridge between parents, teachers, counsellors, and the student. I observed that accountability is strengthened when IEP goals are transparent and shared with all subject teachers, ensuring that support strategies are applied consistently across learning environments.

Another significant observation was the strong emphasis on self-advocacy as a key life skill for students with SEN. Special education teachers consistently encouraged students to read their IEPs and learn about their conditions through tailored subjects such as *Pathways to Independence*. This approach empowers students to articulate their needs, make informed decisions, and take ownership of their learning – skills that are essential for success even beyond the classroom.

I also learned that effective inclusion requires realistic planning that acknowledges teachers' workload and daily pressures. While the IEP provides a valuable framework for goal setting and accountability, the documentation process can at times be extensive. Streamlining it to focus on key elements – such as student background, targeted goals, and specific accommodations – could enhance its usability and consistency across classrooms.

In my audit class, I also appreciated the importance of providing a platform for authentic SEN student voice. Exposure to first-person accounts from individuals with SEN deepened my understanding of the lived experiences behind diagnostic labels. Hearing directly from students and adults describing their educational journeys underscored the importance of empathy, authentic listening, and student voice in designing support systems. At a deeper level, I came to understand that beyond diagnostic labels, most SEN conditions exist along a spectrum, and there is no single way to fully capture or generalise a student's experience. This reinforces the importance of approaching each learner as an individual, maintaining openness to their unique strengths and challenges, and adapting supports responsively rather than prescriptively. Such an approach reflects the heart of inclusive education, where flexibility, empathy, and professional reflection underpin equitable teaching practices.

Results

My observations and secondary research highlighted key considerations for designing effective professional learning in inclusion. An insight was that professional learning must align with teachers' realities – short, flexible, and embedded within their daily routines. This reinforced the value of a bite-sized, reflective learning format that encourages sustained engagement without overwhelming participants. This affirmed the need for a format that promote sustained participation rather than only one-off trainings. First-person accounts of neurodiverse individuals prove especially powerful in deepening empathy and understanding and this would be required for teachers to see beyond diagnostic labels and recognise individual strengths and needs.

The IEP stood out as essential but often administratively heavy. Streamlining it to focus on core goals and accommodations – while involving parents and students in setting those goals—can strengthen ownership and collaboration. Finally, UDL(Cast, 2024) emerged as a framework that benefits all students in the classroom, not only those with SEN. By encouraging flexible teaching approaches, UDL (Cast, 2024) supports inclusive practices that enhance engagement and access for diverse learners.

Educator Project Implementation

My project, “An Inclusive Toolkit for Supporting Adolescent Learners in Mainstream Schools” aims to strengthen teacher capacity to support inclusion in mainstream secondary and post-secondary contexts. The toolkit focuses on four key components, each of which is implemented in a structured sequence to strengthen teacher capacity, support collaborative planning, and embed inclusive practices:

- Micro-Learning Video Series: Short, accessible videos covering inclusive mindsets, and understanding of neurodiversity via largely first-person accounts. Each video is paired with reflection prompts to encourage practical application and gradual development of an inclusive classroom culture.
- IEP Process: A structured approach to co-develop academic, functional, and Positive Behaviour Support (PBS) goals.
- IEP Workshop: A focused professional learning session introducing the IEP process and PBS, supporting practical application and strengthening teacher confidence in collaborative planning.
- UDL Workshop: A workshop on Universal Design for Learning that equips teachers with strategies to design lessons that are accessible, engaging, and equitable for all students, fostering a sense of belonging and inclusion in the classroom.

Implementation will begin in early 2026 with consultation and collaboration among School Leaders, Year Heads, and the Case Management Team (CMT) to refine the proposed IEP-Lite form (See Appendix A: Modified IEP Form) and establish clear processes for its rollout. The IEP-Lite is designed as a collaborative tool that supports co-development of academic, functional, and, where necessary, Positive Behaviour Support (PBS) goals. Importantly, the form promotes shared ownership, with clear action steps assigned to the student, parent, and teachers.

Because the IEP is not legally mandated in Singapore, parent participation cannot be assumed. To ensure parents understand the purpose, scope, and expectations of the process, an IEP Invitation Letter (Appendix B) has been developed. This invitation explains the

collaborative nature of the IEP, the benefits of participation, and sets appropriate expectations so that the meeting remains constructive and grounded in the school's resources and processes. Parents who opt in will be asked to complete a Parent Questionnaire (Appendix C), and students will complete a Self-Advocacy Questionnaire (Appendix D). These tools ensure that the meeting begins with shared clarity and that each participant arrives prepared to discuss the child's strengths, needs, and goals.

In parallel, efforts to build staff awareness and inclusive mindsets will begin in April 2026. A year-long micro-learning series—consisting of short videos on neurodiversity, inclusive mindsets, and SEN awareness—will be released leading up to Neurodiversity Month in April 2027. Each resource will be hosted on Padlet and paired with a reflection prompt to promote sustained, low-threshold professional learning. This approach allows teachers to learn at their own pace and supports the gradual development of an inclusive professional culture. The curated video list and dissemination plan are presented in Appendix E (Neurodiversity Video Resource List).

In January 2027, teachers will attend a focused professional learning session introducing the IEP-Lite process and Positive Behaviour Support (PBS) (see Appendix F for the facilitation plan). This will be followed by an April 2027 workshop on Universal Design for Learning (UDL), which will guide teachers in applying inclusive design principles to their classroom contexts (Appendix G). Following this session, departments will extend the work through their Professional Learning Communities (PLCs), supporting sustained application, peer sharing, and iterative refinement of inclusive practices. Finally, a detailed implementation timeline is provided in Appendix H.

The project has two core aims:

- Teacher empowerment—to build confidence, reflective capacity, and practical competence in supporting diverse learners; and
- Sustainable systems—to embed inclusive frameworks (IEPs, PBS, UDL) within school processes so that inclusive practice endures beyond the project period.

Collaboration remains central throughout. By engaging key personnel early and supporting teachers through ongoing professional learning and reflective dialogue, this project seeks to cultivate a strong, school-wide community of practice committed to meaningful and sustainable inclusion.

Conclusion

Despite decades of effort toward inclusive education, research continues to show that teachers often feel underprepared and under-resourced to meet the diverse needs of SEN students. Early studies reflected optimism about inclusion in principle but persistent concerns about its practicality and resource support (Cornoldi et al., 1998; Forlin et al., 1996). More recent research echoes these same challenges, with teachers still reporting uncertainty about how to effectively design inclusive classrooms and a lack of sufficient training to do so (Nilholm, 2021; Woodcock & Woolfson, 2019; Crispel & Kasperski, 2021). These enduring challenges suggest that inclusion is not achieved merely through policy or placement but through what happens within each classroom.

Central to inclusive education is the teacher's mindset. Research highlights that teachers' attitudes strongly influence how inclusion is enacted in daily practice (Avramidis & Norwich, 2002; van Miegheem et al., 2020; Wilson et al., 2016). Teachers who believe in the

purpose and value of inclusion are more likely to implement it meaningfully, whereas those who feel unequipped or unsupported may struggle despite goodwill (Avramidis et al., 2000; Guillemot et al., 2022; Wilson et al., 2019; Avramidis et al., 2019; Thaver & Lim, 2014). Thus, building teacher confidence, competence, and reflective practice must be at the heart of any sustainable change effort.

The Inclusive Teacher Toolkit seeks to respond to these long-standing gaps by equipping teachers with practical tools and flexible professional learning experiences. Moving forward, the project will focus on promoting mindset shifts through accessible micro-learning, fostering authentic understanding of neurodiversity, and streamlining inclusive frameworks such as IEPs, PBS, and UDL to make them feasible for everyday use. By positioning inclusion as an evolving classroom practice – rather than a dichotomy between mainstream and special settings—this initiative aims to cultivate a community of teachers who can confidently engage with, and celebrate, learner diversity in meaningful and sustainable ways.

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Appendix A

Modified IEP Form

INDIVIDUALISED EDUCATION PROGRAMME

IEP MEETING

IEP Team Meeting Date (dd/mm/yyyy):

IEP Team : Student: [], Parent/Guardian [], Civic Tutor/s [], Year Head/HOD [], SENO []

STUDENT INFORMATION

Name:		Civics Group	
D.O.B		Age:	
Student Phone (Mobile)			
Home Address			
Phone (Home)			

PARENT/GUARDIAN INFORMATION

Name of Primary Contact		Relationship	
Phone (Home)		Phone (Mobile)	
Phone (Work)			
Home Address			

Name of Secondary Contact		Relationship	
Phone (Home)		Phone (Mobile)	
Phone (Work)			

SCHOOL INFORMATION

SUBJECTS OFFERED	J1 SUBJECT TUTORS	J2 SUBJECT TUTORS	

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BRIEF BACKGROUND ON SEN:

--

PRESENT LEVELS OF ACADEMIC ACHIEVEMENT AND FUNCTIONAL PERFORMANCE

Include the following information related to the student:

- Present levels of academic achievement (e.g. most recent results from examinations/formative assessments)

--

- Present levels of functional performance

--

- Parental concerns for enhancing the education of the student

--

- How the student's SEN affects involvement and progress in school

--

- Strengths

--

- Academic, developmental, and functional needs related to student's SEN

<i>Academic:</i>

Functional:

GOALS AND OBJECTIVES

Include, as appropriate academic goals, functional goals and/or behavioural goal.

Academic Goal 1:	Describe WHAT actions the <i>student</i> needs to do.	Describe WHAT the <i>teacher</i> can do to support student in meeting this goal	Describe WHAT the <i>parent</i> can do to support student in meeting this goal
Progress Report 1			
Progress Report 2			

Functional Goal 1:	Describe WHAT actions the <i>student</i> needs to do.	Describe WHAT the <i>teacher</i> can do to support student in meeting this goal	Describe WHAT the <i>parent</i> can do to support student in meeting this goal
Progress Report 1			
Progress Report 2			

POSTIVE BEHAVIORAL SUPPORT PLAN (IF REQUIRED)

Behavioural Support Goal	Describe WHAT actions the <i>student</i> needs to do.	Describe WHAT the <i>teacher</i> can do to support student in meeting this goal	Describe WHAT the <i>parent</i> can do to support student in meeting this goal
Progress Report 1			
Progress Report 2			

ACCESS ARRANGEMENTS

--

TYPE OF ADDITIONAL SUPPORT FOR STUDENT

(Both school-based and private)

--

Appendix B

IEP Invitation Letter

INVITATION TO PARTICIPATE IN THE INDIVIDUALISED EDUCATION PROGRAMME TEAM MEETING

Child's Name: _____

Dear Parent/Guardian _____,

We would like to invite you and your child to an Individualised Education Programme (IEP) meeting to discuss how we can work together to better support your child's learning and well-being in school.

Purpose of the Meeting

The meeting aims to:

- Develop an IEP that outlines your child's learning profile, strengths, and support needs.
- Explore ways the school and family can collaborate to help your child thrive.

While attendance at the IEP meeting is optional, your participation is strongly encouraged, as your insights are vital to supporting your child effectively.

Understanding the IEP

The IEP is not a legal document, but a collaborative plan aligning the efforts of teachers, parents, and your child. It focuses on realistic strategies and goals that are attainable within the school's available resources.

To help us prepare for the meeting:

- You will be invited to complete a **Parent Questionnaire** to share your perspectives on your child's strengths and learning needs.
- Your child will complete a short **Self-Advocacy Form** to reflect on his/her learning experiences and preferences.

IEP Team Members

As a parent/guardian, you are an important member of your child's IEP team. The meeting (approximately one hour) will also include:

- Your child

- Civics Tutor
- Special Education Needs Officer
- Year Head / Assistant Year Head / Head of Department

Your child's Civics Tutor will contact you to arrange a suitable meeting time.

If you have any questions or require clarification, please contact

_____ at _____.

We look forward to meeting with you and working together to support your child's continued growth and success.

Warm regards,

[Name]

[Designation]

[School Name]

Appendix C

Parent Questionnaire

Thank you for taking the time to share information about your child. The details you provide will help us better understand and support your child's learning and well-being at school.

All information shared in this form will remain private and confidential. It will only be used by the support team to plan appropriate strategies for your child and will not be shared with other staff without your consent.

Personal Profile on: _____

Person completing form: _____

Relationship to student: _____

1. What are your child's interests or things he/she enjoys doing?
2. Are there particular activities, foods, or situations that your child dislikes or avoids?
3. How does your child show or tell you that he/she likes something?
4. How does your child show or tell you that he/she dislikes something?
5. How does your child show or tell you that he/she wants to stop doing an activity?
6. How does your child show or tell you that he/she wants to be left alone or needs a break?
7. How does your child show or tell you that he/she wants something or wants to do a specific activity?
8. How does your child usually react when upset or frustrated?
9. What kinds of situations tend to cause your child stress, frustration, or upset feelings?
10. Who are your child's friends or favourite people to spend time with?
11. Are there particular people or situations your child finds difficult or prefers to avoid?
12. How does your child usually interact with others (e.g., peers, adults, siblings)?
13. Is there any other information that would help us support your child more effectively?
(For example, communication style, medical needs, learning preferences, or behavioural considerations.)
14. Do you consent to sharing the information in this form with your child's subject tutors, for the purpose of better understanding and supporting your child's needs?
☐ Yes ☐ No

(Adapted from Wehman. P et al., 2009)

Appendix D

Self-Advocacy Questionnaire

The purpose of this questionnaire is to help you understand yourself better — what you are good at, what you enjoy, and what kind of support helps you do your best. There are no right or wrong answers. Your answers will stay private and will only be shared with your teachers or parents if you agree.

Name:

CG:

1. Three words that describe me are: _____

Understanding my Learning Difference (Special Education Need)

(Use books, reliable websites, or short videos to help you answer.)

2. Do you know the name of your learning difference/special education need?
☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure
 If yes, what is it called? _____
3. What does this learning difference mean? Write a short explanation in your own words.
4. What are some common challenges people with this learning difference might face?
5. What are some common strengths or talents that people with this learning difference often have?
6. Name some famous people who have a learning difference similar to yours.
7. What did you learn about them.

Name of Individual:

What I learnt about this individual:

Name of Individual:

What I learnt about this individual:

8. How does knowing about them make you feel?

Understanding myself

9. What are you good at or proud of?
10. What subjects, activities or hobbies do you enjoy most in your free time?
11. What kinds of things do you find challenging in school? **Use the list below to think about various school situations*

School Situations Guide

You may consider situations like:

In class lessons
 Group work
 Projects or presentations
 Tests and exams
 Physical education lesson or practical subjects
 Break time / recess
 Noisy or crowded places
 Homework
 Moving between classes
 Talking to teachers/classmates

12. What kinds of things upset or frustrate you?
13. When you are upset, worried, or stuck, what helps you calm down or feel better?

Speaking up for yourself

14. What do you wish teachers understood about the way you learn?
15. How comfortable are you talking to teachers or adults about what you need?
☐ Very comfortable ☐ A little comfortable ☐ Not comfortable yet
16. What words or phrases could you use to ask for help or support in class?
17. How can teachers or friends help you become more confident about sharing your needs?

My Goals

18. What is one thing you would like to get better at this year?
19. What are your dreams or plans for the future?

Consent (Optional)

Would you like to share your answers with your teachers so they can understand and support you better?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Yes, but only some parts (please specify): _____

Appendix E

Neurodiversity Video Resource List

Video No.	Title	Duration	Description	Link
Neurodiversity				
1	What exactly is Neurodiversity? Jessica McCabe	6 mins 3 secs (Watch till 3:48)	Explains the neurodiversity movement and establishes that neurodiversity is valuable	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ALJ3CFRRZpo
2	Neurodiversity 101, Pt. 1: An Introduction to Neurodiversity Dr. Beth Radulski	6 mins 50 secs (Watch till 5:17)	Provides a basic introduction to the medical and social models of disability	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2B2r1ChqE4Q
Attention Deficit Hyperactive Disorder				
3	What is ADHD? Jessica McCabe	3 mins 27 secs	Explains common ADHD-related terms.	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xMWtGozn5jU&t=134s
4	Jack and Jill Have ADHD TeenMentalHealth.org	5 mins 24 secs	Illustrates what it's like to have ADHD via a fairy tale we all know too well. Teaches children to believe in themselves and adults that teamwork	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rLghxG3mGMM&t=324s

			and understanding are keys in helping their children succeed despite their diagnosis.	
5	What ADHD Feels Like	2 mins 44 secs	Shares a compilation of interviews with young adults who were diagnosed at a young age. In their commentary, they share what it was like to be a kid with the disorder, and answer questions.	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NL483G4xKu0&t=156s
	<u>OPTIONAL</u> This is what it's really like to live with ADHD Jessica McCabe	17 mins 12 secs	Personal talk about living with ADHD and how community and education helped transformation.	https://www.ted.com/talks/jessica_mccabe_this_is_what_it_s_really_like_to_live_with_adhd_sep_2017?language=en
Autism				
6	Understanding Autism Scott Steindorff	56 mins 51 secs (Watch till 8:53)	Explores autism through interviews, reframing it as a form of diversity.	https://www.pbs.org/video/understanding-autism-vnpjrv/
7	Amazing Things Happen Alexander Amelines	5 mins 30 secs	Introduces autism to raise awareness and promote acceptance among children.	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ezv85LMFx2E&t=271s
8	There's no one way to be autistic Sara Gibbs / BBC	4 mins 34 secs	Animation about being diagnosed with autism as an adult and embracing neurodiversity.	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=otAcBF-fESI&t=37s

Dyslexia				
9	The True Gifts of a Dyslexic Mind Dean Bragonier	(Watch from 7.12-15.56)	Talk reframing dyslexia as a strength and advocating for mindset shifts in education.	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dPyzFFcG7A
10	The Creative Brilliance of Dyslexia Kate Griggs	14 mins 58 secs (Watch till 4:39)	Challenges stereotypes of dyslexia and promotes a strengths-based understanding.	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CYM40HN82I4
Call to Action				
11	Every Child Needs a Champion Rita Pierson	7 mins 48 secs	Inspiring talk on the importance of teacher-student relationships and belief in learners.	https://youtu.be/SFnMTHhKdkw?si=yeOnajHKMS_QPBkA

Appendix F

Facilitation Plan for workshop on Supporting Students through the Individualised Education Plan (IEP)

Workshop Title: Supporting Students through the Individualised Education Plan (IEP)	
Intended Audience:	Teachers in mainstream secondary and post-secondary levels rolling out an IEP in their schools
Duration	50-60 mins
Purpose	Build teacher buy-in, clarity, and confidence in implementing the IEP and PBS processes.
Workshop Objectives:	By the end of the session, teachers will: 1. Understand the purpose and structure of the IEP form. 2. Know their role in the IEP process – before, during, and after the IEP Team Meeting. 3. Understand the basics of Positive Behaviour Support (PBS) and when it is needed. 4. Gain clarity on expectations, communication processes, and follow-up actions.

Opening- Building Buy-In (15 mins)	Materials
Activity – “What We’re Seeing” (Individual) Prompt teachers to provide responses to these questions on a Padlet Board: - What kinds of SEN profiles have you encountered in your classes? - What challenges do you face with SEN students in our college? - How do you think they will fare in university or the world of work? Display the Padlet live and read out a mix of responses to validate the range of perspectives. Synthesise comments and affirm common patterns (Possibly organisation, emotional regulation, disengagement, disruptive behaviour, hygiene, demanding parents etc.) Transition to urgency: Present 1–2 newspaper headlines/statistics showing the rising numbers of SEN students entering secondary and post-secondary (junior college, polytechnic, university) and the difficulties with transitions Share that these issues are not unique to us – they are part of the global landscape. Connect briefly to international context and slow global progress since the Salamanca Statement.	Presentation Slides Padlet Newspaper articles

Lead teachers to see that inclusion goes beyond mere integration and requires some commitment to growth via goals. Facilitator shows that since these challenges are real and predictable, some countries do this via an IEP. The IEP is a way of ensuring no student slips through the cracks.	
Overview of the IEP (15 mins)	
Share a key reassurance message- the intent of adopting the IEP is not to add more work, instead we are creating clarity. The IEP is meant to reduce guesswork, share responsibility, and align parents, teachers, and the student so the burden is not on any one party. Present key messages on IEP. Key Messages: • Singapore does not legally require an IEP—so parent partnership is essential. • The IEP-Lite ensures structured conversations focused on only 2 or 3 realistic, doable goals. • It promotes shared ownership: student ↔ parent ↔ teacher ↔ SEN team. • It helps prevent miscommunication and last-minute crisis management Introduce key components of the IEP form that has been modified to focus on only key aspects • Key components: - Student information - Parent information - School information - Background of SEN - Present levels of academic and functional performance - Goals (no more than 1 academic and 1 functional) - Positive behavioural support plan (if required) - Teacher/Parent/Student commitments to goals - Access arrangements - Types of additional support for student Interactive Mini-Discussion (3 minutes): Prompt: “Which part of this form will make supporting your student more manageable?” - Encourage teachers to name practical elements (e.g., commitments section, student profile). Affirm responses emphasising clarity, communication, and shared responsibility.	Modified IEP form (Appendix A)
Phases in the IEP Process (15 minutes)	

Share the 3 phases of the IEP process: before, during, after. Before the Meeting - Invitation sent to parents of SEN students. - Parents who opt-in complete the questionnaire. - Students complete self-advocacy form. - Civics Tutor coordinates IEP Team meeting. During the Meeting Meeting flow: - Student shares their self-advocacy insights - CMT clarifies with parent - IEP team co-creates 2–3 goals - Define commitments for student, parent, and teachers - Agree on monitoring intervals After the Meeting - Communicate goals to subject tutors - Subject tutors implement commitments to goal and access arrangements - Teachers monitor progress - At each scheduled Parent Engagement Meeting, the Progress Report is updated. Remind teacher of the following: - Share observations respectfully - Avoid diagnostic language - Keep goals realistic and measurable Reassure teachers that “after the meeting” is where small, consistent actions matter. Quick Reflection (1 minute): “What is one habit you can adopt to prepare for IEP meetings?”	Parent Invitation Letter (Appendix B) Parent Questionnaire (Appendix C) Student Self-Advocacy Form (Appendix D)
Introduction to Positive Behaviour Support (PBS) (10 minutes)	
Explain when a PBS plan needed • persistent behaviours that impede learning • behaviours requiring functional understanding 5 Key Parts of PBS (that will be led by SENO): - Functional Assessment - Hypothesis of behaviour	

- Proactive strategies - Replacement behaviour - Reinforcement Walk teachers through example scenarios and normalise PBS as not extra work but merely organising the instincts teachers already use. Example A • Trigger: unstructured group work • Behaviour: refusal to participate • Function: escape from unpredictability • PBS Strategy: provide roles and clear structure Example B • Trigger: Transition time before tutorials • Behaviour: Student shuts down • Function: Escape from task ambiguity • PBS strategy: Clear visual schedule and preview of expectations Emphasise teacher's role in PBS: • Provide observations • Support implementation in class • Reinforce agreed strategies	Example scenarios
Closing the Workshop (3–5 mins)	
Reiterate some Key Reminders • The IEP is a living document. • Focus on realistic, doable goals. • The success of the IEP relies on communication loops. Final Reflection Prompt teachers to submit a quick QR response: “What is one small action you will take before the next IEP meeting?” Reinforce partnership and thank teachers explicitly for their openness and willingness to engage.	

Appendix G

Facilitation Plan for workshop on Universal Design of Learning (UDL)

Workshop Title: Learner Diversity through Universal Design for Learning (UDL)	
Intended Audience:	Teachers in mainstream secondary and post-secondary levels rolling out an IEP in their schools <i>(Participants to be placed into 9 groups)</i>
Duration	Half-day workshop
Purpose	Build teacher understanding, buy-in and skills to apply UDL in their classrooms
Workshop Objectives:	By the end of the session, teachers will: 1. Understand the rationale and structure of UDL. 2. Explore the three UDL principles: Engagement, Representation, Action & Expression. 3. Identify practical UDL strategies relevant to adolescent learning contexts. 4. Plan a lesson redesign applying one UDL principle. 5. Gain clarity on next steps for embedding UDL into departmental practice.

Opening (Energiser Activity) (20 minutes) <i>To show that UDL mirrors the realities of any group of learners, including teachers</i>	Materials
Activity – Invisible Variability Experience <i>(Consider Individual for anonymity especially for sensitive question)</i> Rapidly show and read the prompts for teachers to respond to these questions Learning Preferences - You prefer listening over reading. - You need visuals to understand new content. - You remember better when you write things down. - You learn best through hands-on practice. Attention & Processing - You get overwhelmed when too many instructions appear at once. - You re-read texts multiple times before they make sense. - You multi-task during long presentations. - You lose focus when slides have too much text. Emotional Regulation	Presentation Slides Mentimeter Poll

- You feel anxious when expectations are unclear. - You find it harder to learn when you are stressed. - You shut down when activities move too quickly. Executive Function - You benefit from checklists or planning tools. - You need reminders to stay on task. - You prefer tasks broken into steps. - You avoid tasks when you are not sure how to start. Environment Preferences - You work best in quiet spaces. - You work best with some background noise. - You prefer sitting during learning. - You prefer moving or standing. Communication / Expression - You would rather explain verbally than write. - You need time to think before answering. - You freeze when called on unexpectedly. Acknowledge the wide range of variability shown even among adults in a safe, familiar setting. Emphasise that if much more variability exists among adolescents who are still developing executive function, self-regulation, and identity. Connect to why UDL exists—because classrooms are already diverse, even without considering SEN. Conclude that the issue is that teaching has historically been designed for a mythical ‘average learner.’ UDL helps us design for the learners we actually have.	
Introducing UDL: Foundations & Key Ideas (15 minutes)	
Present a concise, visual overview of UDL. Key points to cover: - Learner variability is the norm, not the exception. - Traditional teaching designs for the “average” student—who does not exist. - UDL shifts from retrofitting accommodations to proactive design.	UDL Guidelines

Emphasise the shift from fixing the learner → to fixing the curriculum design. Explain the CAST framing - Multiple Means of Engagement (the “why”) - Multiple Means of Representation (the “what”) - Multiple Means of Action & Expression (the “how”) Reassure teachers that UDL does not mean creating three versions of every lesson. It means starting with flexibility so one version serves more learners.	
Deep Dive into CAST UDL Guidelines (40 minutes)	
Present the CAST UDL Guidelines chart. Share that the UDL guidelines can help plan learning experiences that reduce barriers and ensure accessible learning experiences for all learners. Begin Expert Group Deep Dive Task (30min) Assign each of the nine groups one of the UDL sub-categories and share access to resources available for that sub-category from the CAST website. Explain that the task is designed to deepen understanding of UDL guidelines. Each group will take ownership of one sub-category and teach it in 10 minutes to others by addressing the guiding questions via google slides. The nine groups will be allocated the following nine sub-categories. Multiple Means of Engagement (the “why”) Grp 1- Design Options for Access Welcoming Interests & Identities Grp 2- Design Options for Sustaining Effort and Persistence Grp 3- Design Options for Emotional Capacity Multiple Means of Representation (the “what”) Grp 4- Design Options for Perception Grp 5- Design Options for Language and Symbols Grp 6- Design Options for Building Knowledge Multiple Means of Action & Expression (the “how”) Grp 7- Design Options for Interaction Grp 8- Design Options for Expression and Communication Grp 9- Design Options for Strategy Development The guiding questions each group addresses are as follows: 1. What learner barriers does this sub-category address? 2. Why is this sub-category relevant in a secondary/junior college context? 3. What design options can teachers adopt in their classrooms?	CAST Website Google Slides

4. What is one concrete classroom example where this guideline could be applied?	
Group Presentations Round 1 – Engagement (30 minutes)	
Invite Groups 1–3 to present their assigned Engagement sub-categories. Each presentation to be no more than 10mins After each presentation, draw attention to two or three practical takeaways relevant to teachers’ contexts.	Google Slides
BREAK (10 minutes)	
Group Presentations Round 2 – Representation + Action/Expression (60 minutes)	
Invite Groups 4–9 to present in sequence. After each presentation, draw attention to two or three practical takeaways relevant to teachers’ contexts.	Google Slides
Whole-Group Synthesis (20 minutes)	
Invite reflection on shared UDL principles. Ask teachers to think about the strategies presented across the nine sub-categories. Prompt them to identify one strategy they already use that aligns with a UDL principle, without naming the principle. Collect quick responses via sticky notes to demonstrate existing alignment with UDL. Consolidate and highlight emerging themes from their responses. Reinforce that many UDL-aligned strategies presented are extensions of current classroom practices, not additional workload. Position UDL as a framework that brings intentionality and coherence to practices teachers are already familiar with. Prompt forward action. Ask teachers to identify one UDL strategy they would like to try or refine in their teaching. Have them submit this idea via Padlet to support accountability and sharing across departments. Close the session by acknowledging the collective expertise in the room and reinforcing that UDL is a continuous, iterative process. Encourage teachers to carry their selected strategy into upcoming lessons and to share successes or challenges during department or PLC time. Remind them that the goal is not perfection, but steady progress toward designing learning environments that anticipate and embrace learner variability.	Parking Lot with post-its Padlet with department columns
LUNCH BREAK	

Appendix H

Project Timeline (Implementation Plan)

Timeframe	Key Actions
Jan-Feb 2026	- Share proposed implementation plan with School Leaders, Year Heads and SEN officers. Make revisions based on feedback.
Feb- Mar 2026	- Share cleared implementation plan with Case Management Team. - Seek support for collaboration.
Apr 2026- Oct 2026	- Begin collaboration with Case Management Team on the IEP form and the IEP process.
April 2026- April 2027 (Start and end coincides with Neurodiversity Month)	- Release of short videos and reflection prompts on neurodiversity, inclusive mindsets, and SEN awareness.
Nov 2026	- Share implementation IEP implementation plans and process with Key Personal to gather feedback and obtain buy-in.
Jan 2027	- Conduct session introducing IEP implementation and Positive Behaviour Support (PBS).
April 2027	- Conduct session introducing Universal Design for Learning (UDL) - Continue Padlet engagement during Neurodiversity Month; monitor implementation and gather feedback.